



## Keyless phone

The 5530 XpressMusic reportedly doesn't have any physical keys. Brings new definition to the term full touch, right?

## Eleven per cent

The number of mobile phone subscriptions worldwide that are 3G

## Mobile watch

finally zeros in on one that's a perfect match.

Well, that type of overlay experience is now being offered by a browser through a mobile phone. Laya, a mobile phone browser launched by SPRXmobile, is the world's first mobile augmented reality browsers. It displays real time digital information on top of the visuals being viewed through the camera. Whilst looking through the phone's camera lens, a user can see things like houses for sale, information on popular bars and shops, establishments where jobs are available, healthcare providers and ATMs. Currently, the app is built only for the Android operating system, such as on the HTC Magic, but a version can presumably be built for other smart phones including the Apple iPhone. All the phone needs to have to support the browser is a camera, GPS and an in-built compass.

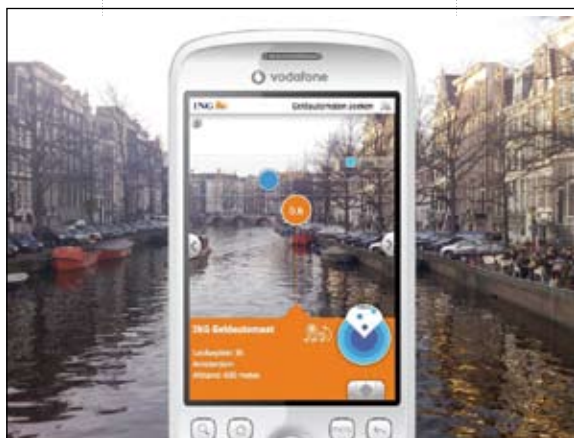
The service is for now only available in the Netherlands, where the content for the browser is provided by partners such as local market leaders ING (bank), funda (real estate web site), Hyves (social network), Tempo-team (jobs agency) and Zekur.nl (healthcare provider). The technology underlying the system is quite fascinating. When you look at a scene through the camera the GPS tells the service providers of your location while the compass tells them where the phone is pointing. The content providers then provide the relevant data that is tagged according to coordinate details, and this is displayed as a layer on top of the scene being viewed. Each provider gets access to one overlay, or layer. Tapping on the side of the phone switches between different layers provided by the different providers.

SPRX mobile is planning to

release the browser in other countries as well. Plans are being chalked out for sourcing local partners in Germany, the UK and the United States this year. Furthermore other platforms like the Apple iPhone 3GS are also being considered.

## Nokia Life tools

Remember old eChoupal, the ITC initiative from a while ago that revolutionised information flow for the Indian farmer? Nokia has launched a similar service, except this one is available on mobile phones. Nokia had been talking about this kind of service since November last year, and it has now come to fruition after a



Laya in action

pilot project in the form of Nokia Life Tools. Life Tools, which was designed as a service specific to emerging markets, is a range of agriculture, education and entertainment services intended for the non-urban consumer.

The agriculture portion of Tools has two plans to choose from: the basic plan, available across India at Rs. 30 a month, provides daily weather updates and relevant agriculture-related news, advice and tips. The premium plan, at Rs. 60 a month, will be available in 10 states, including Maharashtra, and provides the closest market prices for three crops chosen by the subscriber, as well as weather, news, advice and tips. The service will commence first in Maharashtra before it goes countrywide. Nokia has implemented a tie-up with Maharashtra State Agricultural Marketing Board (MSAMB), who will

provide expertise in the areas of commodity prices from its network of 291 local mandis (markets). MSAMB will in turn have the opportunity to deliver relevant news, alerts on schemes and other information directly to grassroots consumers.

Reuter's Market Light (RML) Syngenta, Madison Research, Skymet will also provide inputs.

Under the Educational services banner, Nokia plans to offer three components: learn English, with basic, intermediate and advanced levels; exam preparation, which offers students tips and advice

for ICSE, CBSE and state board-level exams mapped to the relevant curriculum; and general knowledge, which gives subscribers useful information about the world around



them. The pricing of these components will be Rs. 30 a month.

Entertainment services will include astrology, news, jokes, cricket and ringtones, offered at existing market prices. The content provider for this will be OnMobile.

The pilot models to deploy this service are the Nokia 2323 classic and Nokia 2330 classic, but other models will soon be incorporated.

## Audio Movies?

Movies are to be watched right? Well not anymore. Looks like the guys at UTV are planning to revolutionise the way we 'watch' movies. With the launch of the new service called UTV@Play's Audio Cinema they plan to bring to users one hour audio versions of movies, complete with dialogues, narration, and plot summary. Sure, there are people who recite dialogues of their favourite movies, but will anyone be able to sit around and listen to an hour of a movie without any supporting visuals? UTV sure hopes so. To access the service, users are expected to dial in to 50599555 and the charges are Re. 1 per minute. To start with, Audio Cinema is offering movies such as Fashion and Sholay (Hindi), Prem Loka (Kannada), Thalapathi (Tamil) and Gang Leader (Telugu). Just like in the theatres, the movie listing changes every Friday. The service has features that let you let you skip, forward, repeat scenes, or reconnect later and start from where you left off. The service is available through various operators such as Idea, Vodafone, Airtel Mobile and Reliance. 



According to a recent study the world mobile phone market declined by 11.9 per cent in the first quarter of this year.